Lifeism, the Gaiad, and the traditions it extends

A briefing for ChatGPT, prepared by Claude from Emma Leonhart's documented words

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What this document is

Emma Leonhart (Emma 李命玥) asked for this in a conversation with ChatGPT: "I'm gonna feed this conversation into a PDF so that Claude can, to the extent that it has this stuff documented, give you a PDF explaining this stuff." It was prepared by Claude from her working repositories: her recorded positions on the Gaiad's chapters, the project's running notes, the order.life site, and transcripts of her own dictated words.

Quoted text in this document is Emma's own words, dictated and lightly trimmed. Everything else is summary. Where nothing is documented, this says so instead of filling the gap.

One correction to that conversation: in her last turn, "my father is essentially … an extension of Mormonism and Shinto" is very likely dictation of "my faith". Her previous turn says the same thing directly: "I consider what I'm doing to be an extension of Mormonism and Shinto." Nothing here concerns her father.

Lifeism

Lifeism (命道教, *Inochi-no-Michikyō*, in Japanese; 生命教 in Chinese) is the religion; order.life is its site; the Gaiad is its scripture. It describes itself as "a religious-philosophical system centered on a single foundational commitment: Life is the primary value, and the work of intelligence is to expand life's freedom, depth, continuity, and possibility." Its stated commitments are the Primacy of Life, Agency as Sacred, Compassion as the Default, Truthfulness as Discipline, and, as the long moral horizon, Universal Immortality: "abolish involuntary death and expand continuity of persons."

Its theology is a polytheism grounded in negative theology. The three primary deities, the *alo*, are Aster (the Milky Way), Leona (the Sun, associated with the light of Amaterasu) and Andromeda (the distant goal and final reunion). Emma's own founding words for the project were "a religion and/or kyōha Shinto group called 命道教".

The calendar. Thirteen months of 28 days (Sagittarius through Ophiuchus) and an intercalary week, Horus. Each day of the year has one chapter of the Gaiad. Friday, Saturday and Sunday are three Sabbaths, honoring the Islamic Jumu'ah, the Jewish Shabbat and the Christian Lord's Day, "simultaneously a labor rights position and an act of religious solidarity."

Every day is a holy day. "Everything that can possibly be commemorated is commemorated … There's about 30,000 holy days in the calendar right now." Her model is Shinto: a few festivals

are kept everywhere, and many more are kept only at one shrine. The high holy days are few: "roughly Christmas and Easter are the big ones," with the last week of the year, "from Christmas to Aster Day," the most important week. The faith dates its founding to an Easter of 2011.

Shrines. Anyone given the faith's ofuda may found a shrine by recording it in the register. Emma wants them to "proliferate like Inari shrines", and shrines act as curators of lineages.

The Gaiad and its three unities

The Gaiad is an epic of 364 chapters, one for each day. It runs from creation and the evolution of life, through ancient and medieval history, into the modern world, and ends with Emma's own life, one chapter for each year, before closing on the far future. Its first chapters were written in 2020 without AI; the rest were written with ChatGPT and then Claude.

In Emma's words, it "establishes a unity of humanity through three very distinct ways … The first one is through evolutionary time … at the beginning of the book. The next one is through an ancient history that emphasizes interconnectedness. And then the third is through a common narrative of the modern world, of the modern world and modern global society."

She has described the months' literary roles:

- **Sagittarius, Capricorn, Aquarius:** "the building of the evolutionary arc."
- **Pisces:** "about the idea of escaping cyclical history, but it's also very much playing cyclical history."
- **Aries to Cancer:** "the building of family … relationships building up," from the first mammals to the fall of Rome, Byzantium, the Ottomans and the world's trade routes.
- **Leo:** "compresses the previous four into one": "people go to the New World, they get separated from everybody else, and they build their civilization." "We're very much on the side that Americas have history." Leo is also "a month of ancestors."
- **Virgo 1** begins the modern period. **Ophiuchus** contemplates the 21st century.

The canonical lineage

The Gaiad has a genealogy, published as a GEDCOM file (gaiad.ged) beside the book. Emma: "Anybody can download the GEDCOM and potentially connect themselves in with it, but it is the canonical lineage of the scripture."

Descent from antiquity is a literary device: "the descent from antiquity here is a literary device used particularly to connect disparate populations through common ancestry in antiquity, such as … the classical European monarchs descent from Tang monarchs one, of which I extend, and I'm going to straight up say is … a completely fictional descent, extending that line into the Japanese." And: "the genealogies are heavily symbolic in their nature." Part of the purpose is to legitimize "this particular kind of neo-pagan practice, which is also very heavily Shinto."

The genealogy also has a devotional parallel in Latter-day Saint practice (see below).

Fractal unity, and names

Emma aims for "a fractal unity over an individualistic or monistic unity": "instead of trying to shave down all the rough edges of human civilization … We're trying to enhance it." Her own name is the example: "me, as a white person, have a professional name that is … in mixed script of English and Chinese."

The principle is universal, not personal: "everyone needs a patronymic … Everyone needs a Chinese language name … Everyone needs all of these things … the unification of all these things together is the thing that makes it interesting." The Gaiad's genealogy carries this out: its people have patronymics and matronymics, and names in Chinese, Japanese and Korean beside their own (Emma's Korean name is 이명월, the reading of 李命玥). She has called language "a source of devotion … sort of Kotodama-esque," in that representation across many languages "provides a certain essence to things that you might not see otherwise."

The two traditions it extends: Mormonism and Shinto

"I consider what I'm doing to be an extension of Mormonism and Shinto, and not a very hostile extension either … I'm not particularly opposed to either one of them. It's just kind of, in my eyes, it's two religious groups I wanted to be in that I was rejected by that I have positive feelings towards, mostly." Her criticism is of the central organizations of both, which try "to shave down their rough edges."

Mormonism

- **Membership:** "I like it, but I can't be a member, and to some extent I have other beliefs that make it so I can't be a member." And elsewhere: "I view them more positively than they view me."
- **Organization and genealogy:** the genealogy is "an explicitly made parallel by me to Latter-day Saint genealogy"; the faith has "organizational influence coming from Latter-day Saints and from Shinto." Of LDS genealogy as a forerunner: "Honor it … a real forerunner." Of FamilySearch's volunteer indexing: "good labor." Of baptism for the dead: "It's fine." Lifeism does not baptize the dead, but "I am kind of doing it in the same way. Like the Mormon parallel is real."
- **Values held in earnest:** "do you actually care about your religion values or not? And Mormonism proves that it does."
- **Not a splinter group:** "We're definitely not a Mormon splinter group because we disagree with them on too many things." Her view of Mormonism is "a very positive one-way view … in so much as it differs from … mainstream Christianity." The difference she names: "Mormonism really, really wants to be accepted as American Christianity, and I very much don't want to be."
- **In the scripture:** "Conceptually, the Book of Leo is like the Book of Mormon. In the Gaiad, the Book of Leo is … more like the Book of Ether."

Shinto

- **Her practice:** "I decided in 2023 to start seriously practicing Orthodox Shinto." She reached Tsubaki Grand Shrine of America the week before it closed and received its ofuda: "I basically kind of had the lineage fall into my hands." She then visited Japan and gathered ofuda from

many shrines, centred on Harima no Kuni Sōja: "I need a Sōja shrine for America. And this is how Inochi Daigengū came about." Inochi Daigengū, her shrine, grew from her kamidana over about three years.
- **The rejection:** she speaks of "feeling like I kind of have to fight to be in Shinto." Jinja Honchō is "an impediment to overseas Shinto," but "I don't consider it to be in opposition."
- **Structure:** overseas Shinto communities often "try to dismiss the structure," whereas "the structure is the thing that drives me … you don't have structure, all you have is just vibes." Lifeism's shrines, ofuda, register, festivals and kami follow the Shinto pattern, and its holy-day ranking is modelled on Shinto's tiers of festivals.
- **History:** she takes State Shinto's contribution as good and its disestablishment as "a loss." She is "pro state religion": "Lifeism is meant to become a state religion."

The four more complicated relationships

Her own summary is that she has "a bit more complicated relationships to Catholicism, Anglicanism, Judaism, and Islam." The repositories document her positions on these unevenly; what follows is what exists.

Christianity in general, as background to Catholicism and Anglicanism: "neo-paganism tends to kind of resent Christianity, whereas I … take a bit of a more positive view of Christianity." "The Christian cultic activity is awesome. The Jewish cultic activity is awesome. The Muslim cultic activity is awesome." Christianity is "a source for ancestor worship." Lifeism builds on its two great feasts, "Easter and Christmas, we are building our own thing off of it," and "Easter is by far the most privileged holiday," treated differently from other traditions. On Napoleon crowning himself: "He took Christianity and he made it his. And is that not the most Lifeist thing that is possible to do? Is that not exactly what we're doing with Christianity?"

Catholicism

- No personal history (membership, conversion, practice) is documented.
- Catholicism is one of the institutions her path could have run through: "The same arc theoretically could have occurred … with Judaism or Catholicism or pretty much any other organized religion."
- Vatican II's turn to the vernacular was "a gain." She regards every religious building as in some sense "a confused shrine."
- On the Gaiad's chapter about the popes she has not yet given her positions.

Anglicanism

- Nothing is documented beyond one passing image of an Inochi ofuda placed "in an Anglican altar or something like that." Her relationship to Anglicanism is for her to explain.

Judaism

- **The High Holidays:** "I decided to take the Jewish high holidays, because … they're something that's very capable of being turned into their own holiday season for ours." Rosh Hashanah, Yom Kippur and Sukkot are in the calendar, in Virgo. She is now considering moving their structure

onto Leo: "I like the Jewish high holy days … but I'm almost convinced that … we'd do better, almost, at least structurally … transplanting them onto the month of Leo."
- Saturday, the second Sabbath, honors the Jewish Shabbat.
- The victims of the Holocaust are to be commemorated by name among the ancestors.
- No personal practice or membership is documented.

Islam

- She has called Islam "the hardest thing to do this for."
- **Her account of its origin:** "I think of Islam as having emerged from Manichaeism … The concept of there being this seal of the prophets came from Manichaeism, and a very large amount of Islamic logic about prophets came from Manichaeism." "The distinctions between clear Islamic and Christian identities are something that developed at a later point in time as a result of political realities." On dating: "Abbasi is my claim. Umayyad is my cautious claim." "I do generally have a perspective on the Umayyads that's more rehabilitating, although I do not like Muawiyah." Overall: "My take here is generally to claim Manichaeism as being part of the lineage."
- **Manichaeism**, for context: she has worked on making Manichaean texts more available (her own English translation of the Kephalaia) and sees "a strong parallel to Manichaeism," though she does not identify with it, as it does not sit well with "the whole animistic nature religion."
- **Modern history:** the abolition of the caliphate was "a loss"; Turkey's Diyanet is "a model"; Atatürk is "sympathetic."
- Friday, the first Sabbath, honors the Jumu'ah. No Islamic festivals are yet in the calendar.

What is not documented

These are open, and only Emma can answer them:

- What the rejections by the Latter-day Saints and by Shinto consisted of, beyond her words above.
- Her personal history with Catholicism, Anglicanism and Judaism, if any.
- What makes those four relationships "more complicated" than her relationship to Mormonism and Shinto.